

WHO

The A Method for Hiring

GEOFF SMART & RANDY STREET

The Big “So What”



Almost every company finds it challenging to find and hire the right talents. The #1 problem isn't about the right strategy, products or processes; it's about finding and putting the right people in the right roles so they can make the right decisions and deliver outcomes that matter. The A Method for Hiring is a proven 4-step approach that you can use to hire A Players in any level of your organization.

Understanding the #1 Problem



Focus on Who, not What

? Who vs What. Many leaders focus on the “Whats” in their organizations, e.g. the strategies, products and services, systems and processes. However, without the right people in the right place, whatever problems you fix will only resurface again. It's much more critical to focus on the “Whos”, i.e. having the right people to make the “What” decisions. Once you address the “Who”, the “What” will naturally fall in place.

✗ After interviewing many CEOs, leaders and management experts, and then analysing the data in detail, ghSMART found 4 key mistakes that lead to hiring failures at all levels (from a front-line worker to a CEO):

- Lack of clarity on what the job requires;
- Lack of good candidates;
- Inability to choose the right candidate; and
- Losing the selected candidates.

KEY QUOTES

“The most important decisions that businesspeople make are not what decisions, but who decisions.”
- Jim Collins

“In business, you are who you hire.”



Such hiring mistakes are costly—besides wasting valuable recruitment time and resources, the wrong people can make bad decisions that hurt the company and team morale.



Hiring the Right People with the Right Approach



Most traditional recruitment and interview techniques are ineffective because they don't test if someone can really do a job well. Specifically, there are 10 common approaches that lead to poor hiring decisions—ghSMART calls them "voodoo hiring methods".

- The art critic uses gut instincts to make quick (and often inaccurate) decisions.
- The sponge allows everyone to interview every candidate, resulting in wasteful duplication.
- The prosecutor tests candidates' knowledge with quizzes and questions (which don't really correlate with performance).
- The suitor is obsessed with selling the job rather than evaluating the candidates.
- The trickster uses tricks to test the candidate (e.g. leaving things on the floor to see if the candidate would pick it up).
- The animal lover asks questions like "if you were an animal, what animal would you be?"
- The chatterbox wastes time on small talk.
- The personality tester makes decisions based on psychological/personality tests, which may not predict job success.
- The aptitude tester tests for aptitudes (e.g. persistence) which may be relevant but are inadequate for decision-making.
- The fortune teller asks hypothetical questions which won't tell you what the candidates would *actually* do.

KEY QUOTES

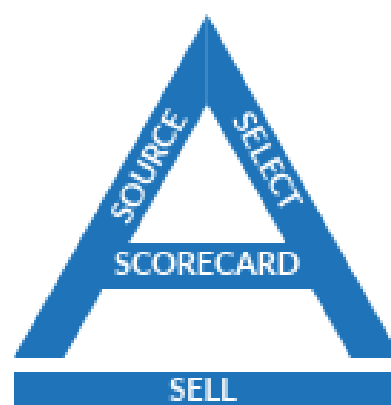
"One of the painful truths of hiring is this: it is hard to see people for who they really are."

- ★ Ultimately, you want to hire A Players who fit with your company culture and can accomplish a specific job with high standards. ghSMART defines an A Player as "a candidate who has at least a 90 percent chance of achieving a set of outcomes that only the top 10 percent of possible candidates could achieve". The question is: how can you find, identify and successfully hire these A Players?

The 4-Part Approach for Hiring A Players



The ghSMART A Method for Hiring is a simple, proven 4-step process to identify and hire A players at all levels of the organization. In the book, the authors used the strokes of the alphabet "A" to present the 4 components. We have used a different graphical representation in this summary.



1. Develop the Job Success Blueprint

- Mission
- Outcomes
- Competencies

3. Identify A Players with 4 Interviews

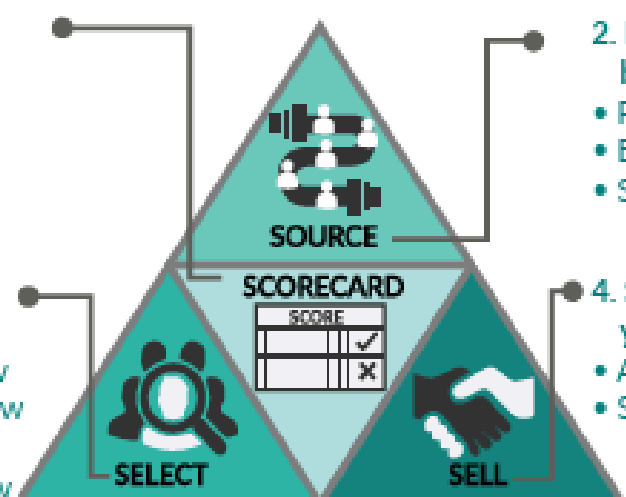
- Screening Interview
- Topgrading Interview
- Focused Interview
- Reference Interview

2. Build a Talent Pipeline before it's needed

- Referrals
- External Recruiters
- Sourcing Systems

4. Secure the Candidate you want

- Appeal to the 5Fs
- Sell in 5 Phases



Scorecard: Developing your Success Blueprint

You can only build a house with a blueprint. Likewise, you can only hire the right person with a scorecard. The scorecard is a job blueprint—it describes exactly what success in a role looks like, including the (i) mission (why the role exists), (ii) outcomes (what the person must deliver) and (iii) competencies (how the job should be done given the job requirements and company culture).

 Mission = the job's essence or core purpose.

KEY QUOTES

"Hiring A Players takes hard work...You have to dig hard, ask tough questions, and be prepared sometimes for disturbing answers."

"Scorecards are your blueprint for success. They take the theoretical definition of an A Player and put it in practical terms for the position you need to fill."

- Keep it succinct and precise e.g. "Double revenues from business clients in 2 years by securing new accounts and growing existing accounts." Limit it to 1-5 sentences and avoid vague terms like "maximize shareholder value" or "improve efficiency".
- Don't hire generalists or all-rounders. Hire specialists who have the specific, in-depth competencies needed to succeed in a job. It's like how you'd go to a brain surgeon for a brain surgery instead of a general practitioner. This means that the existing managers must get crystal-clear on what's required. For example, are you looking for a visionary leader who can develop new markets, or someone to consolidate and systematize the existing businesses?



Outcomes are what must be achieved to get an "A" rating.

- A job will typically have 3-8 specific, measurable outcomes e.g. "grow revenue from business clients from \$10mil to \$20mil by 31 Dec 2020".
- When the targets are explicit and challenging, you will automatically weed out the B and C Players and attract A Players with the right skillsets.



Competencies are behaviors that'd fit the job outcomes as well as the company culture.

- Competencies define how a new hire should achieve the job mission and outcomes. You must address 2 sets of competencies:
 - (i) Job-specific skills and behaviors needed to achieve the outcomes; and
 - (ii) Cultural competencies to ensure organizational fit (these should appear on every scorecard).
- Based on their research and experience, ghSMART found that most A Players have several vital competencies such as accountability, analytical skills, assertiveness, attention to detail, efficiency, honesty, initiative, learning abilities, organization skills, and persistence.

KEY QUOTES

"The mission should help you find not the generalist who points you to the problem but the very best specialist to help you solve it."

"The first failure point of hiring is not being crystal clear about what you really want the person you hire to accomplish."



Scorecard ↔ Strategy. You can't develop great scorecards without first having clarity on your company's strategy and culture. Unfortunately most managers start hiring with only a vague idea of what's required, or using a general/standard job description.

- Start by crystallizing your strategy and goals, and translating them into specific objectives and activities for each person in the organization. That's the only way to directly link individual jobs to the overarching strategy.
- A good scorecard should reflect your business plan and the needs of all key stakeholders. All parties should agree on the scorecard and feel excited at the prospect of having someone like that on the team. The scorecard creates alignment, lets the candidate know how exactly he/she will be evaluated, and can be used to monitor and evaluate performance after the person is hired.
- The job role/requirements will change over time as the company faces different challenges/opportunities. Thus, a scorecard must be updated/recrafted each time you rehire; you can't simply reuse the scorecard. Here's an example of how a scorecard may look like:

BUSINESS SALES DIRECTOR, ABC INC. MISSION: Double revenues from business clients in 2 years by securing new accounts and growing existing accounts.	
OUTCOMES	RATINGS/COMMENTS
1. Grow revenue from business clients from \$10mil to \$20mil by 31 Dec 2020. • Add 50 new business accounts with at least \$100k contract value each • Grow existing business accounts by 50%, by up-selling and cross-selling the 5 new product lines A, B, C, D and E	
2. Build & lead a team of 15 sales professionals. • Build a hunting team to secure new accounts • Build a farming team to grow existing accounts • Ensure 100% of sales team are A Players • Provide coaching & mentorship for team.	
3. Design and implement sales training for all customer-facing staff by 31 Dec 2019	

KEY QUOTES

"Scorecards translate your business plans into role-by-role outcomes and create alignment among your team, and they unify your culture and ensure people understand your expectations."

"Scorecards...ensure not just that you have A Players but that the A Players are delivering A performances."

"Scorecards need to be evolving documents, not static ones."

"Properly constructed and used, scorecards spread strategy through every aspect of your organizational life."

COMPETENCIES	RATINGS/COMMENTS
Can hire A Players	
Innovative	
Analytical	
B-to-B Sales	
Follows through on Commitments	



Source: Building a Pipeline of A Players



Most managers don't plan in advance. When a position opens up, they pull out an old job description and rush to fill the vacancy; a handful of candidates are shortlisted given the limited time and info, and one of them is hired using voodoo methods. **Sourcing is about systematically looking for and identifying potential talents *before* you actually need the people.**



The best way to find A Players is through referrals, not advertising.

- Get referrals from your personal and professional networks. Each time you meet someone who asks you "what do you do?", explain what you do and ask "Who are the most talented people you know that I should hire?" You can also list down the most talented people you know, and approach them to ask the same question. If you deliberately speak with 1 person a week, you'll build a pipeline of potential talents.
- Referrals from employees. Your employees know your company well, and can be one of the best sources of new hires. Teach them to ask the sourcing question above, and add sourcing as an outcome on every employee's scorecard. You can also reward or incentivize people for their sourcing contributions.
- Tap on your business network by offering bonuses or gifts to partners and affiliates who successfully refer candidates to you.

KEY QUOTES

"Talented people know talented people, and they're almost always glad to pass along one another's names."

"By turning employees into talent spotters, everyone starts viewing the business through a who lens, not just a what one."



You can use external recruiters and/or researchers to supplement your hiring efforts—the main difference is that researchers will only identify potential candidates without qualifying or interviewing them. Help your recruiters to know your company thoroughly—share your scorecards and get their suggestions for improvement.



Once you have a flow of potential candidates, you need sourcing systems (e.g. index cards, software systems) to capture the contacts and follow up with them. The goal is to dedicate time weekly for sourcing, and to keep track of the talents and your conversations with them. Even if they're happy with their current jobs, you can still get to know them and ask if they know other talented people.



Select: Identify the A Players using 4 Interviews



Traditional interview techniques don't predict job performance because they focus on how someone behaves during the interview rather than on their track record. You need a structured approach to gather info and evaluate candidates against the Scorecard. You're looking for A Players who have a history of delivering the desired outcomes, have competencies that fit the role and culture, and are passionate about the role.



The screening interview. Sift out the B and C Players quickly using a short (30-45min) phone-based interview. You can potentially weed out 80-90% of the candidates at this phase, thus saving yourselves lots of unnecessary time and energy later on.

- Review the scorecard before the call.
- Start by setting the right expectations, e.g. "I'd like to take the first 20 min of our call to get to know you. Then, I'd be happy to answer your questions so you can get to know us. Is that ok?" The idea is to hear from the candidate before he/she is influenced by what you say about the job or company.
- Then, use these 4 key questions:
 - (i) "What are your career goals?" Listen for a fit between their personal goals and your company needs, as well as their passion for the things found in or required for the job.

KEY QUOTES

"Talent is what you need. Focus and commitment will get you there."

"Talented people know what they want to do and are not afraid to tell you about it."

(ii) *"What are you really good at professionally?"* Ask them to share 8-12 positive traits with specific examples, so you can understand these strengths in context.

(iii) *"What are you not good at or not interested in doing professionally?"* People may be less forthcoming with this than (ii), so you may need to prod for the real answers. If need be, explain that at the next step of the selection process you'll be asking to speak with references like their former bosses/peers/subordinates, then ask "What do you think they will say you're not good at or not interested in?"

(iv) *"Who were your last 5 bosses, and when we talk to them, how will they each rate your performance between 1-10?"* You only want candidates with scores of mainly 8-10.

- Tips:

(i) When people believe that you *will* be talking to their ex-colleagues, they're more likely to respond honestly.

(ii) Stay curious—keep probing for details and clarification by asking "what" and "how" questions (e.g. "what do you mean?", "how did that happen?"). Invite them to elaborate with 3 words—"tell me more".

(iii) Once you have clear picture, invite the candidate to ask questions. If you like what you hear, proactively sell to the candidate using your new insights. If not, shorten the call.

- After the call, ask yourself if there's a match with the scorecard given the candidate's goals, strengths and weaknesses. Only bring someone to the next phase if you're truly excited that this could be *the* right person.



The Topgrading Interview. This interview covers the candidate's career in a chronological order, using 5 questions to draw out specific facts and stories about each career phase. By the end of 3-5 hours, you'll have a much clearer assessment of the candidate.

KEY QUOTES

- Start by setting the expectations e.g. "We're going to walk through each job you've held, in chronological order, with 5 key questions for each job. After that, we'll discuss your career goals and aspirations, and answer questions you may have. Is this ok?"
- The interview will feel like a natural conversation. If you stay curious and keep using what/how/tell me more, you'll get lots of useful info from the candidate. The 5 key questions are:
 - (i) "*What were you hired to do?*" Your goal is to get an idea of what their scorecard would've looked like if they had one.
 - (ii) "*What accomplishments are you most proud of?*" Listen out for outcomes related to the job you're hiring for. Beware of candidates who talk about events, people or activities without addressing actual results.
 - (iii) "*What were some low points during the job?*" Be prepared to reframe this question a few times to get a real answer.
 - (iv) "*Who did you work with?*" Specifically, ask for the boss' name (and how to spell it), what it was like working with him/her, and what the boss will say the candidate's biggest strengths vs areas for improvement are. When interviewing for a management role, also ask them to rate the team they inherited, the changes they made, whether they hired/fired anyone, and to rate the team when they left it. Make sure you sound like you *will* be talking to these references.
 - (v) "*Why did you leave the job?*" A Players tend to leave their jobs for *pull* factors (e.g. being hired by a client/ex-boss or being offered a bigger role). B to C Players tend to be *pushed* out of their jobs (e.g. conflict with their boss/colleagues, missed targets or having their role reduced).
- Tips:
 - (i) To keep the interview on point and on time, you'll have to *interrupt* the candidate regularly. The key is to smile and jump in enthusiastically on something they said (e.g. "wow that sounds like an exciting party!"), then bring

KEY QUOTES

the discussion back to point (e.g. “You were just sharing about the new product launch earlier. I’ve love to hear how that went!”).

- (ii) Clarify the value of their accomplishment by asking them to compare the results against 3Ps: the previous year’s performance, the plan and their peers’ performance.
- (iii) Listen out for *pull vs push factors*—don’t hire anyone who left $\geq 20\%$ of their jobs for push factors.
- (iv) Keep asking questions until you have enough details to paint a *clear mental picture* of exactly what happened in their previous jobs.
- (v) Look out for *subtle cues* that the candidate is lying or withholding info, e.g. shifting in the seat or avoiding eye-contact. Be curious and ask questions till the truth emerges.



The focused interview. This interview takes about 45-60 minutes, and the goal is to dig deeper for info on specific outcomes or competencies in the scorecard. You can also involve other team members, but make sure they follow the recommended script to avoid going off-tangent, e.g. assign 3 interviewers to focus on 2 outcomes and 2 competencies each.

- Always include competencies specific to the job and to the culture. Set the expectations for each interview, e.g. “The goal of this interview is to understand more about ____ (state the outcome or competency).”
- Then dive in with 2 questions:
 - (i) “What are your biggest achievements in this area throughout your career?”
 - (ii) “What lessons have you learned from your biggest mistakes and what insights have you gained in this area?”



The reference interview. You’re now ready to test what you learned about the candidate through reference checks. Never skip this step.

KEY QUOTES

“Keep asking until you understand what the person did and how he or she did it.”

- For your reference interviews to be effective, (i) pick the references from your interview notes instead of using the candidate's list, (ii) get the candidate to set up the interviews, and (iii) aim for 7 reference checks (ideally 3 former bosses, 2 peers/customers, and 2 subordinates).
- Ask these 5 questions, using how/what/tell me more to probe deeper:
 - (i) "In what context did you work with (the candidate)?"
 - (ii) "What were (the candidate's) biggest strengths?"
 - (iii) "What were (the candidate's) biggest areas for improvement back then?"
 - (iv) "How would you rate his/her overall performance on a scale of 1-10 scale? What aspects of his/her performance led to this rating?"
 - (v) "(The candidate) mentioned that he/she struggled with ____ in that job. Can you tell me more about that?"
- Most people don't want to give a bad reference, so you have to listen for false positives and what's not being said. Some tell-tale signs include: the use of qualifiers, pauses, "ums" and "ers", or a lack of enthusiasm. A true A Player should call up a genuine sense of admiration and energy in the ex-colleague.



Deciding who to hire.

- Throughout the interview process, red flags may surface, e.g. the candidates may speak badly of past colleagues, seem self-centered, avoid talking about failures or find excuses for themselves. Don't ignore these tell-tale signs—keep asking questions and you may be surprised by the truth that emerges. Only move someone to the next phase of the interview if you're convinced they could be the ideal candidate.
- A candidate will have $\geq 90\%$ chance of success if he/she has both the skills (that match the desired outcomes) and the will (that matches the mission and competencies). After the 4

KEY QUOTES

"Under the pressure of a hiring decision, even obvious clues can slide right past otherwise highly astute people."

"A truly positive reference... should brim with tremendous enthusiasm and obvious admiration."

interviews, complete the scorecards and give each candidate an overall grade of A, B, or C. Only hire A-graders. If you have no A-graders, keep sourcing; if you have multiple A-graders then hire the best.



Sell: Secure the Candidate



Your job is not done until the candidate is delivering results as your employee. To get them through the door, you must sell to them by sincerely appealing to the 5Fs that people care about.

- Fit. Show the candidate how his/her goals, talents, and values fit with your organizational vision, strategy and culture, as well as the job mission, outcomes and competencies.
- Family. Win over the family, especially if a relocation is involved—show them around, have meals with them, and make them feel at ease and excited about the shift.
- Freedom. A Players don't want to be micromanaged; they need the freedom to drive their results and prove themselves. Help them believe that they can thrive in your organization.
- Fortune. You can rarely win over an A Player just by throwing money at him/her. However, you can link performance objectively to the scorecard outcomes. A Players will be confident of achieving those results and find it fulfilling to earn top dollars for top performance.
- Fun. The definition of “fun” will vary with each culture and individual. However, if there's a genuine fit, the candidate should find it fun and enjoyable to take on the job in your company.



In reality, you'll have to sell *throughout* the recruitment process, not just at the end. Specifically, you must sell across 5 phases of the hiring process: during sourcing, during interviews, while waiting for the candidate to accept your offer, after the offer has been accepted, and during the new hire's first 100 days on the job. You can lose the person at any point in this process. Listen for concerns regarding the 5Fs and address them immediately. Do your best to maximize your A Player's chances of success.

KEY QUOTES

"Don't fumble the ball as you run across the goal line. You are not finished until your candidate becomes an employee."

"The key to successfully selling your candidate to join your company is putting yourself in his or her shoes. Care about what they care about."

Conclusion



Implementing the A Method for Hiring



Hiring A Players takes deliberate effort, hard work and persistence. However, the results are worth it, since the right talents will influence/shape your company culture/direction and define your long-term success. Eventually, your goal should be to build an A-team, i.e. a team of A Players, each with their own strengths suited for a specific role.



You don't have to be a CEO to use the A method of hiring—it can be applied at any level in an organization, be it a department, business unit or a function.

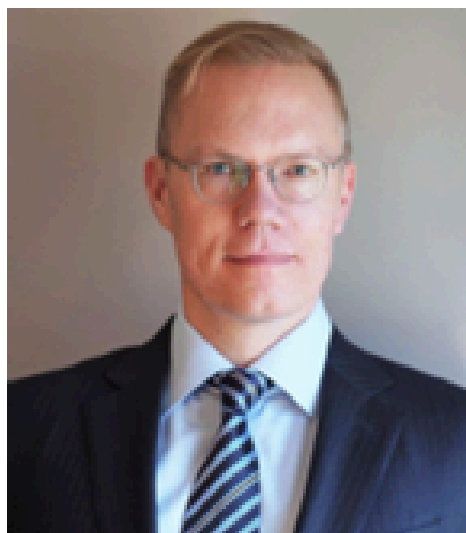
Other Details in the Book to Look out For



This is a clear, structured guidebook to hiring A Players. Besides the highlights in this summary, the book includes many other tips and insights, including: red flags or behavioral warning signs to look out for, 10 things required for installing the A method, legal traps to avoid, and numerous examples with specific scripts and phrases to help you get the most from your hiring process. For more details, please visit <https://whothethebook.com/>.

About the Authors

Geoff Smart (born 1972) is an entrepreneur, speaker and author. He's the chairman and founder of ghSMART, a leadership advisory firm that helps companies with hiring, developing and leading talented teams. In 2017 and 2018, Forbes named ghSMART as the best management consulting firm in its industry segment based on surveys of business leaders.



KEY QUOTES

"Collectively, (A Players) form an A team because they know how to pull the oars together. They propel your business forward by making unique contributions that add up to something greater than the sum of parts alone."